

THE TURN INWARD

Autumn is the beautiful goodbye.

The almanac is at its most tender now. *Kanro*, cold dew; then *sōkō*, frost descends. The *kō* inside them read like a slow leave-taking: "wild geese return," "chrysanthemums bloom," "maple leaves and ivy turn yellow." Everything is at its most beautiful precisely because it is about to be gone.

That feeling has a name the Japanese have polished for a thousand years: *mono no aware* — the quiet, aching awareness that things are moving and will not stay, and that their passing is the very thing that makes them lovely. Autumn is the season that teaches it without trying.

At home, it turns us back inward. The doors that stood open all summer close; the wool comes down from the shelf; the light goes amber and low. This is *hygge*'s true season — not the marketed candle-and-blanket version but the older instinct: to make a warm, gathered refuge against the coming dark, and to fill it, while we can, with the people and the worn, imperfect, beloved things that have lasted.

Gather what you love, light it warmly, and let the season be beautiful because it ends.

